

KELSEY PUKELIS

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kelseypukelis.com

EDUCATION

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 2025 (expected)

Ph.D. in Public Policy (Economics Track)

Fields: Public Economics, Labor Economics

Research Interests: Social Safety Net Policy, U.S. Nutrition Assistance Policy

Northwestern University, Evanston, IL 2017

B.A. in Economics, Mathematics, Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences (triple major)

Interdisciplinary Honors in Economics & Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences

Cum Laude; Phi Beta Kappa

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

California Department of Social Services, Sacramento, CA June 2025 (planned)

Research Data Analyst

Research, Automation, and Data Division

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Harvard Kennedy School of Government, Cambridge, MA

Poverty & Public Policy (Master of Public Policy)

Spring 2025

Guest Co-Lecturer with Professor Mark Shepard

Quantitative Analysis & Empirical Methods II (Master of Public Policy)

Spring 2023

Teaching Fellow for Professors Michela Carlana, Benjamin Schneer & Teddy Svoronos

Resources, Incentives, & Choices II: Analysis of Public Policy (Master of Public Policy)

Spring 2022

Teaching Fellow for Professor Mark Shepard

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA

Advanced Topics in Impact Evaluation (Master of Public Policy)

Fall 2018

Teaching Assistant for Professor Sally Hudson

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Microsoft Research New England, Cambridge, MA

Summer 2020

Research Intern with Eleanor Dillon

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA

2017 – 2019

Frank Batten School of Leadership & Public Policy

Research Specialist Intermediate to Jennifer Doleac, Sally Hudson, and Adam Leive

Northwestern University, Evanston, IL

2014 – 2017

Two-Generation Educational Research Team, Institute for Policy Research

Research Assistant to Lindsay Chase-Lansdale and Teresa Sommer

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Scholar in Inequality, Harvard University	2021 – 2025
National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship	2021 – 2024
Harvard Graduate Prize Fellowship	2019 – 2021

RESEARCH GRANTS

Institute for Quantitative Social Science Graduate Student Research Grant, Harvard University	2024
Malcolm Wiener Center for Social Policy Qualitative Research Grant, Harvard University	2024
Stone Research Grant, James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Program in Wealth Distribution, Inequality & Social Policy, Harvard University	2023
Division of Social Sciences Fund (with Michael Holcomb), Harvard University	2022
Mind Brain Behavior Graduate Student Award (with Alice Heath), Harvard University	2021
Harvard Center for American Political Studies Graduate Seed Grant (with Alice Heath)	2021

PUBLICATION

“Employed in a SNAP? The Impact of Work Requirements on Program Participation and Labor Supply” (with Colin Gray, Adam Leive, Elena Prager, and Mary Zaki)
American Economic Journal: Economic Policy, 2023, 15(1): 306-341.

Work requirements are common in US safety net programs. Evidence remains limited, however, on the extent to which work requirements increase economic self-sufficiency or screen out vulnerable individuals. Using linked administrative data on food stamps (SNAP) and earnings with a regression discontinuity design, we find robust evidence that work requirements increase program exits by 23 percentage points (64 percent) among incumbent participants. Overall program participation among adults who are subject to work requirements is reduced by 53 percent. Homeless adults are disproportionately screened out. We find no effects on employment and suggestive evidence of increased earnings in some specifications.

WORKING PAPERS

“SNAP Policies and Enrollment following the COVID-19 Pandemic”

Policy responses to the COVID-19 pandemic provide a unique opportunity to understand the effects of a more generous and accessible U.S. safety net. This paper investigates the importance of policy changes versus economic conditions in explaining caseload and denial surges following COVID-19 in the context of the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP). I compile a new dataset on state policy waivers, including unprecedented flexibilities in application and recertification procedures and increases in benefit amounts (Emergency Allotments). In contrast to prior periods, policies—rather than business cycle changes—drove enrollment increases. Among all policies examined, emergency supplemental benefits and recertification waivers policies increased caseloads more than policies that simplified applications and recertifications. Descriptive evidence suggests that application denial rates increased both because recertification waivers cut off the typical flow of approved applications from otherwise churning cases and because relatively higher income households were more likely to apply.

“Stigma and Social Safety Net Program Participation” (with Alice Heath & Michael Holcomb)

Negative social judgements or “stigma” about the receipt of government benefits may discourage participation and impose costs on those already receiving benefits. But who experiences stigma, how it affects participant decisions, and whether it can be reduced remain unclear. In this paper, we use a nationally representative survey experiment to measure levels of stigma across social groups and test whether interventions intended to alleviate stigma may affect participation in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), the U.S.’ largest, means-tested food assistance program. We find that our interventions have polarizing effects: they increase stigma among Republicans and current SNAP participants and decrease stigma among Democrats and non-participants. One intervention that dismantles a common zero-sum concern (that receiving benefits would prevent others from receiving them) increases take-up among eligible non-participants, as measured by completing an online eligibility screener. However, all our interventions decrease support for SNAP spending among Republican respondents. Our findings indicate the importance of both social norms and political orientation for influencing participation in government transfer programs in this context.

“The Impacts of Online Grocery Shopping with SNAP”

Many anti-poverty programs are in-kind rather than cash, and adoption of new technologies can affect program access for participants (the demand side) and potential profits for third-party vendors (the supply side). In this paper, I investigate the growth of online purchasing with public food vouchers across food retailer markets and its effects on low-income consumers (SNAP and Pandemic EBT users). Relative to stores authorized to accept benefits in-person, stores authorized for online purchases were more likely to be large retailers and to be located in advantaged neighborhoods, suggesting that retailers did not target online shopping toward low food access areas (food deserts). Then, using quasi-experimental spatial variation, I find that exposure to online purchasing shifted some benefit spending from in-person to online but had no detectable effect on SNAP enrollment. This project describes a drastic change to the delivery of nutrition assistance programs and has implications for other in-kind benefit programs.

RESEARCH PAPERS IN PROGRESS

“Dynamic Enrollment in Transfer Programs: Evidence from Disaster SNAP” (with Laura Blount Carper)

“Automatic Enrollment in Transfer Programs” (with Claire Leroy)

“The Health Impacts of SNAP Work Requirements” (with Bradley Katcher)

POLICY WRITING

Public comment to the U.S. Food and Nutrition Service’s Proposed Rule: “Establishing the Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer Program and Rural Non-Congregate Option in the Summer Meal Programs” (FNS-2023-0029). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), August 27, 2024.

Public comment to the U.S. Food and Nutrition Service’s Proposed Rule: “Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Program Purpose and Work Requirement Provisions of the Fiscal Responsibility Act of 2023” (FNS-2023-0058). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), June 14, 2024.

Public comment to the U.S. Food and Nutrition Service’s Proposed Rule: “Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children: Online Ordering and Transactions and Food Delivery Revisions to Meet the Needs of a Modern, Data-Driven Program” (FNS-2022-0015-0001). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), May 26, 2023.

“SNAP work requirements don’t actually get more people working — but they do drastically limit the availability of food aid.” *The Conversation*, April 2023.

CONFERENCE & SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

“Stigma and Safety Net Program Participation”	June 2025 (planned)
American Society of Health Economists (ASHEcon) Annual Conference	
“SNAP Policies and Enrollment following the COVID-19 Pandemic”	November 2024
Virtual Economics of Poverty & Public Policy Seminar (VEPPS, short presentation)	
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (APPAM) Research Conference	
Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting	
“The Impacts of Online Grocery Purchasing on SNAP Households”	July 2023
Agriculture & Applied Economics Association (AAEA) Annual Conference	
“SNAP Application Policies and Enrollment during the COVID-19 Pandemic”	July 2022
Western Economic Association International (WEAI) Annual Conference	

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Referee,	<i>Agriculture & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting</i>	
	<i>Journal of Policy Analysis and Management</i>	
	<i>Quarterly Journal of Economics</i>	
Reviewer,	<i>Oxford Bibliographies</i>	
Student-Faculty Engagement Co-Chair,	Harvard Kennedy PhD Student Association	2022 – 2023
Social Committee Co-Chair,	Harvard Kennedy PhD Student Association	2021 – 2022
Student Organizer,	Harvard Econometrics Reading Group	2020

MENTORING

Invited Panel Speaker,	Northwestern University’s Womxn in Economics Student Group	Fall 2023
Mentor,	Harvard Undergraduates for Inclusion in Economics	2022
Mentor,	MIT / Harvard Economics Application Assistance and Mentoring Program	2021 – 2022
Peer Mentor,	Harvard Public Policy PhD Program	2020 – 2022
Classroom & Language Consultant,	University of Virginia	2018 – 2019

AFFILIATIONS

Social Economics Lab, Harvard University, Affiliate
Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University, Affiliate
Mosaic Economic Project, Progressive Policy Institute, Alumna
American Economic Association Mentoring Program, Mentee
Agricultural & Applied Economics Association, Member

SKILLS

Computer	Proficient in Stata, R, L ^A T _E X, Git/GitHub, Microsoft Office Experience with Qualtrics, Python, HTML, BASH, ArcGIS, Matlab
Language	English (native), Spanish (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (basic)

REFERENCES

Professor Marcella Alsan Harvard University marcella_alsan@hks.harvard.edu	Professor Jeffrey Liebman Harvard University jeffrey_liebman@hks.harvard.edu
Professor Mark Shepard Harvard University mark_shepard@hks.harvard.edu	Professor Stefanie Stantcheva Harvard University sstantcheva@fas.harvard.edu